

Five Steps to Financial Wellbeing

work on my financial situation, started to notice how connected some of my worst and most nonsensical decisions were to my almost non-existent self-esteem, I was suddenly faced with the sheer number of different ways in which trying to please or impress other people can cost you financially. There are the obvious, direct things, such as gift-giving and being unable to say no to expensive plans with other people, and then there are the wider ripple effects, such as spending on yourself as a pick-me-up because you're too busy looking after others to meet your own basic needs. Since I was quite young, I've been an obsessive gift-giver. Only the perfect gift will do – thoughtful, expensive, meticulously chosen. If there's an inside joke, throwback or deeper spiritual meaning, even better.

The problem with putting all of your resources into other people is that the feeling of having satisfied someone else's needs doesn't last long. It needs to be constantly topped up, and we end up ignoring our own needs in favour of becoming a sort of buffet of emotional resources for those around us – a constant conveyor belt of little portions of our energy, doled out to others before we ever take any for ourselves. We don't put our own oxygen masks on before assisting others and, after a while, this 'selflessness' – which actually stems from a desire to be liked – becomes expected by others, and it's even harder for us to change our behaviour without fearing that we will offend or hurt them.

One of the most common pieces of advice I'm asked to give is how to say no to other people where money is concerned –